Case Analysis: Cross-cultural Bugs in a U.S.-Malaysia high-tech project.

Part-1:

1. **Key communication or cultural misunderstanding:**

- Language & Indirectness: Americans struggled to understand English(accent) and Malaysian culture, including indirect feedback and face-saving practices prevalent among Malaysians. This led to misunderstandings, repeated clarifications, & unspoken confusion, especially in virtual & group interactions(Meyer 2014).
- Feedback: Malaysian members often remained silent or gave vague agreement in response to issues or feedback-a cultural approach of avoiding confrontation & preserving harmony, but misinterpreted as incompetence or agreement when neither was true(Meyer 2014; Miike 2008).
- Repetition of Failure: A continuous failure in work for the same reason (air bubbles), confirms previous "understanding" as false. The subsequent frustrated confrontation by the American engineer exemplifies direct confrontation, which contrasts sharply with the Malaysian's indirect approach, resulting in further silence.
- Work Rhythms & Socialization: Americans expected punctuality, structured meetings, & business-focused lunches; Malaysians prioritized relationship-building, extended social meal times, & flexibility in scheduling, which U.S. members considered as inefficiency.
- Management Styles & Power Structure: U.S. manager, Dale, approached conflicts with direct debate & assertion, while Malaysian had collaborative approach. This led to public disputes, authority confusion, & residual friction among managers & engineers(Miike 2008).

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2. **Analyse the cultural values, norms, or assumptions involved**(Javidan & Dastmalchian 2009; Javidan & Dorfman 2012)**:**

Dimension	USA	Malaysia	Explanation
Power Distance	Low (egalitarian, challenge authorities)	High (hierarchy, deference)	Dale confronted Kong publicly; Kurt disliked decision-making autonomy of Kon
Assertiveness	High (direct, confrontational)	Moderate (indirect, harmonizing)	Dale confronted Kong publicly; Malaysians responded vaguely & rarely challenged, causing errors.
In-Group Collectivism	Moderate	High, Collectivist, group loyalty, values trust.	Malaysia-mum-mum breaks, long lunches; Subordinates bonding despite managerial tensions; Kurt & Teng's bonding.
Institutional Collectivism	Low, individual focus	Social harmony	U.S. aligned by specialty, Malaysians assigned by whole assembly
Humane Orientation	Moderate	High (care, relationship)	Americans grew frustrated when meals & socializing took up work time (trust-building acts).
Uncertainty Avoidance	Moderate	Higher (ambiguity undesirable)	Delay & lateness in meetings, differing approach to schedules (e.g., supplier visits); Kong seeks advice from Kurt more than Dale.
Future Orientation	Plan for goals, schedules	Flexible, short-term adapt	Issues with time management, delays in responding to emails, & decision-making

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Performance Orientation	Punctual, deadlines matter	Flexible timing; prioritize relationships	Frustration over repeated quality problems & lack of proactive communication

3. Missing or underdeveloped elements of CQ:

- Cognitive CQ-Understanding Malaysian hierarchical and collectivist communication styles & the role of social time in business.
- Motivational CQ-Curiosity & genuine interest in Malaysian approaches beyond the initial business trip; most U.S. staff remained culturally confined(Meyer 2014).
- Behavioural CQ-Limited adjustment in meeting structure, feedback style, & conflict resolution approaches, despite evidence that American tactics were counterproductive in the Malaysian context(Miike 2008).
- Metacognitive CQ-After-the-fact analysis & superficial briefings (e.g., "don't use your left hand," "give & receive business cards properly") failed to learn adaptive leadership behaviours.(Meyer 2014)

Higher CQ would have altered the strategy in numerous ways: Americans could have planned agenda-free social time, asked clarifying questions even after agreement, & adopted inclusive decision-making; Malaysians could have been trained to express misunderstandings openly in remote settings & flag pending disagreements before technical escalation(Molinsky & Gundling 2016; Javidan & Zaheer 2019).

4. Lessons learned:

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- Embrace Multiple Perspectives: Effective global leaders avoid national stereotypes. Deep understanding of cultural dimensions prevents mis-judgments & promotes adaptive leadership (Javidan & Dastmalchian 2009; Meyer 2014).
- Importance of Trust: Trust-building differs by culture, ranges from task & results-based trust in the U.S. to relationship & character-driven trust in Malaysia. Leaders must actively negotiate & cultivate these trust dynamics (Javidan & Zaheer 2019; Molinsky & Gundling 2016).
- Celebrate Harmony: Global leaders should value cultural differences as synergistic assets. Respecting cultural diversity strengthen team cohesion & innovation without forcing premature consensus (Miike 2008; Adler 2002).
- Structural Supports for CQ: Successful team require cross-cultural communication protocols, rotating meeting leadership, & scheduled social bonding for continuous cultural learning. Proactive leadership that creates these frameworks enables diverse teams to operate effectively over time (Molinsky & Gundling 2016).
- Active listening & Decision-Making Styles: Understanding and respect how different cultures handle conflict, criticism, and decision-making enables leaders to modify their approach. For instance, direct feedback & debate may energize U.S. teams but annoy Malaysian who prefer indirect communication (Meyer 2014;Ferrari 2012; Javidan & Dorfman 2012).
- Foster Inclusivity: Encouraging multiple inputs & feedback facilitated engagement. Inclusive decision-making respects hierarchical & egalitarian tendencies (Javidan & Zaheer 2019).
- Commit to Cultural Learning & Reflection: Cultural intelligence is a dynamic capability requiring ongoing self-awareness, curiosity, & adjustment. The case showed

that ineffective assumptions about partner behaviour, language comprehension, & time hindered collaboration & trust (Condron et al. 2004).

By integrating these lessons, future global leaders can approach cross-cultural teams with humility, empathy, & strategic flexibility. They can create environments where trust is earned through culturally aligned behaviours, mistakes are mitigated through communication, & team diversity becomes a source of competitive advantage to unlock high performance in global teams.

Part-2:

1. **Major differences between the U.S. & Malaysian cultures**(Javidan & Dastmalchian 2009; Meyer 2014)

Dimension	**United States**	**Malaysia**
Power Distance	Low: Value equality, challenge authority, flat hierarchy	High: Accept hierarchy, respect authority, formal structure
Uncertainty Avoidance	Moderate: Comfortable with ambiguity, flexible rules	High: Prefer clear rules, avoid ambiguity, structured processes
Institutional Collectivism	Low: Individual achievement, personal responsibility	High: Group loyalty, team harmony, collective decisions
In-Group Collectivism	Moderate: Teamwork valued, but less than personal goals	High: Strong group identity, prioritize relationships

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Assertiveness	High: Direct, open debate, explicit feedback	Low: Indirect, diplomatic, avoid confrontation
Performance Orientation	High: Reward results, focus on achievement	Moderate: Value group success, less focus on individual achievement
Humane Orientation	Moderate: Fairness valued, but task-focused	High: Compassion, care, social support emphasized
Future Orientation	High: Plan ahead, short-term & long-term goals	Moderate: Consider future, but value tradition

Similarities(Javidan & Zaheer 2019; Molinsky & Gundling 2016; Kramer; Miike 2008):

- Values teamwork & reliability.
- Respect for expertise/roles.
- Use deadlines but differently.
- Desire for reliable deliverables.
- Use English in business, but with different communication styles.
- Highly skilled engineers & technical expertise.
- Share a strong organizational culture of APC, which provides some common ground despite cultural differences.
- Strive for quality outcomes & organizational success.

2. Causes of the problems encountered:

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The main cause is Intercultural communication breakdown rooted in diverse culture & the U.S. team's ethnocentric approach.

- Incompatible Communication Codes: American's demand on explicit, verbal verification clashed with the Malaysian preference for implicit, non-confrontational communication. Malaysian's face-saving norms provided false affirmation rather than admitting confusion, leading to the repeated plating defect failure.
- Lack of Relational Trust: The Americans failed to cultivate high degree of relational trust in a collectivist, high-context culture. The repeated technical failures & the withholding of problems until parts were shipped suggest that Malaysians did not view the Americans as trusted resources whose input should be sought during fabrication. Dale's reaction of calling them "renegades" & imposing additional bureaucracy was an unhelpful, ethnocentric response.
- Time Orientations: American's expectation of promptness clashed with the Malaysian team's observed behaviour of delays. This lack of punctuality further contributed to American frustration & questioning of the Penang engineers' commitment.

3. **Specific recommendations and steps for U.S. & Malaysian groups for the next two months:**

For the U.S. Team:

- Recommendation-Adapt communication, respect hierarchy, and build relationships to foster trust and efficiency.
- Undertake deep-dive CQ & Culture Map sessions focused specifically on Malaysian contexts, emphasizing hierarchical, indirect feedback, & relational trust-building(Meyer 2014; Javidan & Dastmalchian,2009).

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- Redesign feedback loops-introduce "closed-loop" communication where responsibilities & confirmations are always documented (Javidan & Zaheer 2021).
- Appoint "cultural translators" to interpret unspoken signals & clarify intent in real time, especially during virtual meetings(Molinsky & Gundling 2016).
- Rotate meeting leadership: Encourage Malaysian team members to lead sessions, fostering ownership and inclusion.

For the Malaysian Team:

- Recommendation-Increase transparency, clarify expectations, and educate American colleagues on local norms.
- Promote the clear expression of difficulties clarifying when agreement has not actually been reached(Molinsky & Gundling 2016; Miike 2008).
- Propose changes that balance U.S. efficiency with Malaysian relationship values.
- After teleconferences, send summaries that note issues, agreements, and items needing further explanation.
- Educate U.S. colleagues on the value & necessity of socializing & flexible time use, framing relational activities as vital elements of task completion(Miike 2008).

For Both Teams:

- Establish a joint, living "Cross-Cultural Communication Charter," spelling out norms for meetings, time use, feedback, & escalation-review & revise biweekly(Molinsky & Gundling 2016).
- Schedule informal "face-to-face" sessions before each major agenda item to enable affective trust & personal insight.

- Alternate meeting leads & rotates agenda-setting to strengthen mutual accountability & voice(Molinsky & Gundling 2016).

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